

Nathaniel Bonham

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SUMMARY

User researcher, product strategist, and mentor with a master's degree in Human-Computer Interaction and over 10 years of experience leading user-centered decision-making for large-scale digital products with global audiences (Halo Infinite, JSTOR, The Sims). I'm passionate about building participatory research cultures, aligning cross-functional teams through a shared understanding of users and problems, and bridging business goals with user needs to identify and drive strategic priorities.

RELEVANT EXPERIENCE

Electronic Arts Senior User Researcher

Ann Arbor, MI (remote)
10/2023 - 06/2025

Player researcher for The Sims' "Project Rene," a mobile-first, multiplayer concept in The Sims franchise.

Responsibilities:

- Combined end-to-end quantitative and qualitative research to inform UI, gameplay, controls, visual style, fashion, and multiplayer frameworks for Project Rene.
- Collaborated with developers via agile ceremonies (sprint planning, retrospectives, requirement sessions), ensuring alignment and trust between research and development.
- Managed leadership stakeholders and built relationships across consumer insights, data analytics, and operations.
- Mentored researchers by reviewing study materials, editing reports, and advising on stakeholder relationships.

Accomplishments:

- Aligned the studio's development culture to mobile-first and new-to-franchise players by communicating research-driven narratives about these players' needs, mental models, expectations, and values.
- Created a participatory research culture by designing and facilitating cross-team scoping workshops, studio-wide playtest viewing sessions, and multi-channel insight sharing (1:1s, show & tells, Slack, studio-wide all hands).
- Improved controls' ease-of-use score by 55% by identifying usability issues and expectations of mobile-first players.
- Coached teams on interpreting behavioral data (BigQuery, Looker) to ensure insights were understood and actionable.
- Shifted EA's competitive analysis program from broad product evaluations to a targeted, decision-driving framework that informs product strategy.

ITHAKA Senior User Researcher

Ann Arbor, MI
12/2019 - 10/2023

Research partner on JSTOR's Tools+Teaching team; led multi-platform integration for a product with 150M+ global visitors.

Responsibilities:

- Managed all phases of research, including roadmaps, hypothesis writing, study design, stakeholder management, session moderation, data analysis, tools selection, and presentation of insights to all of JSTOR.
- Combined quantitative and qualitative insights to align the platform to users' needs and increase usage.
- Partnered with product, design, and engineering leadership to co-create annual Strategy, Metrics, and Tactics roadmaps, define KPIs, author OKRs, and embed research into agile development processes.

Accomplishments:

- Successfully integrated Artstor into JSTOR through company-wide adoption of a user-outcomes framework I developed that detailed user needs, motivations, and behaviors.
- Combined usability testing, surveys, Google Analytics, and A/B testing to inspire and validate a major redesign of JSTOR's content viewer leading to a +16% increase in platform ease of use.
- Streamlined departmental research documentation, increasing discoverability, shareability, and reusability of insights.
- Co-authored a mobile heuristics guide adopted by product and design teams to improve JSTOR's mobile experience.
- Mentored an Associate User Researcher, guiding career growth and contributing to their promotion.

Microsoft

User Research Specialist (contract via Harman International)

Redmond, WA

10/2017 - 11/2019

Primary researcher for Halo Infinite's multiplayer gameplay, user-generated content tool (Forge), and onboarding experience.

Responsibilities:

- Designed, executed, and analyzed studies to inform multiplayer game loops, gameplay modes, and map design.
- Combined and synthesized behavioral, telemetry, and observational data to reveal how design decisions impact player comprehension, engagement, and replayability.
- Scoped and conducted monthly internal tests ("Day of Play") by partnering with design leads, coaching lab moderators, analyzing results, and communicating findings to design leads at 343 Industries.

Accomplishments:

- Delivered the research and insight foundations that prompted a major redesign of Halo Infinite's multiplayer framework, better aligning product direction with the expectations and motivations of current fans and first-time players.
- Guided the multiplayer team to design a new player experience (FTUE, "The Academy") by communicating needs and learning goals of new-to-franchise players.
- Informed a redesign of Halo's user-generated content tool ("The Forge") that better met player mental models by conducting usability studies, heuristic evaluations, and secondary research.

EDUCATION

University of Michigan

Master of Science in Information

Ann Arbor, MI

09/2015 - 04/2017

- Concentration: Human-Computer Interaction, User Experience Research and Design
- Graduate Student Instructor, SI 310 — Information Environments and Work
- Summer Internship at Blizzard Entertainment, 2016

University of Michigan Ross School of Business

Bachelor of Business Administration

Ann Arbor, MI

09/2001 - 04/2005

- Concentration: Business Administration & Marketing

SKILLS

Research & Insight Methods: A/B testing, behavioral analytics, competitor analysis, concept testing, ethnographic research, experimental design, focus groups, heuristic evaluations, in-depth interviews, mixed-methods research leadership, playtesting, RITE studies, surveys, usability studies, user journey mapping, workflow analysis

Tools & Platforms: Alchemer, Asana, BigQuery, ChatGPT, Excel, Figma, Google Analytics, Looker, Miro, Mural, PlaytestCloud, Qualtrics, UserTesting.com, Tableau

Organizational Processes: Agile, design sprints, empathy mapping, insight-to-action frameworks, mentorship and coaching, opportunity solution trees, OKRs, participatory research practices, research democratization, roadmapping, SMART goals, Strategy Metrics Tactics workshops, user outcomes frameworks